

Rapid Neurodevelopmental Assessment

Australian Edition

2026 Manual Update

What's New?

We have made some important updates to the RNDA-AUS Manual and created supporting resources to improve clarity, consistency, and ease of administration for all!

New Age-Specific
Manuals & Scoring
Forms

Updated item
numbering system
for easier reference
and navigation

Revised test item
instructions with
clearer wording

More illustrations
& photos

Age-Specific Manuals & Scoring Forms

To quickly identify the test items required for a specific age group, you can use the **Age-Specific Manuals**, which contain only the relevant items for that age group across each domain.

When administering and scoring the RNDA offline, the **Age-Specific Scoring Forms** allow you to print and score items as you progress through the assessment.

As the RNDA test items are organised into 32 age groups across the 0 - 5 Years and 5+ Years Manuals, 32 Age-Specific Manuals have been developed.

Instructions for Administration:

Birth to < 1 Month

Note Ensure to wash your hands before handling the child and to handle the child gently. For neonates and young infants (<3 months) offer a little bit of time after testing each item, to allow the infant to settle.

Definitions

Plane: In reference to items requiring holding a body part on the same plane as another, this refers to being level to.

Prone Position: The prone position refers to lying horizontally with the face and torso facing down. The infant lies with knees drawn up under the abdomen with pelvis high. Head is turned to one side.

Supine Position: The supine position refers to lying horizontally with the face and torso facing up.

Ventral Suspension: The baby is placed in prone position and suspended in the air by a hand placed under the chest. The head hangs down with some flexion of elbows and knees.

1.0 Primitive Reflexes

1.0.1	Reflex: Rooting	Age: Birth - < 1 month
Materials	Padded Surface, Hygienic Gloves	
Overview	The rooting reflex is well established by 32 weeks gestation. It is demonstrable in the newborn period and then fades during the early months.	
Instructions	Place the infant in supine position, head in the midline. Touch one corner of the mouth and stroke laterally. Do this on both sides.	
Response	Turning of the head in the direction of the stimulus, simultaneous opening of the mouth and extension of the tongue.	
Grading	Present Weak None	



Instructions for Administration:

13 to 16 Years Old

2.1 Gross Motor

2.1.1	Walks steadily	Age: 10 - 16 Years
Materials	Toy/Object	
Instructions	Use incidental observation or place an object at a distance from the child and ask the child to get it.	
Response	Observe if the child is able to walk steadily without assistance.	
Scoring	Able Not Able	

2.1.2	Climbs stairs steadily with alternate feet, not holding on	Age: 10 - 16 Years
Materials	Staircase	
Instructions	Stand the child at the lower end of a staircase. Ask the child to climb at least three or four stairs. If needed, prompt to walk with alternate feet.	
Response	The child should be able to climb stairs without support (e.g., handrail), with alternate feet.	
Scoring	Able Not Able	



32 Age-Specific Scoring Forms can support paper-based scoring during administration.

RNDA-AUS: AGE-SPECIFIC SCORE FORM			
FORM	Age Range		
1	Birth to <1 month old		
Child Name:		Chronological Age:	
Test Date:		Corrected Age (if applicable):	
Birth Date:		Sex:	
Examiner:			

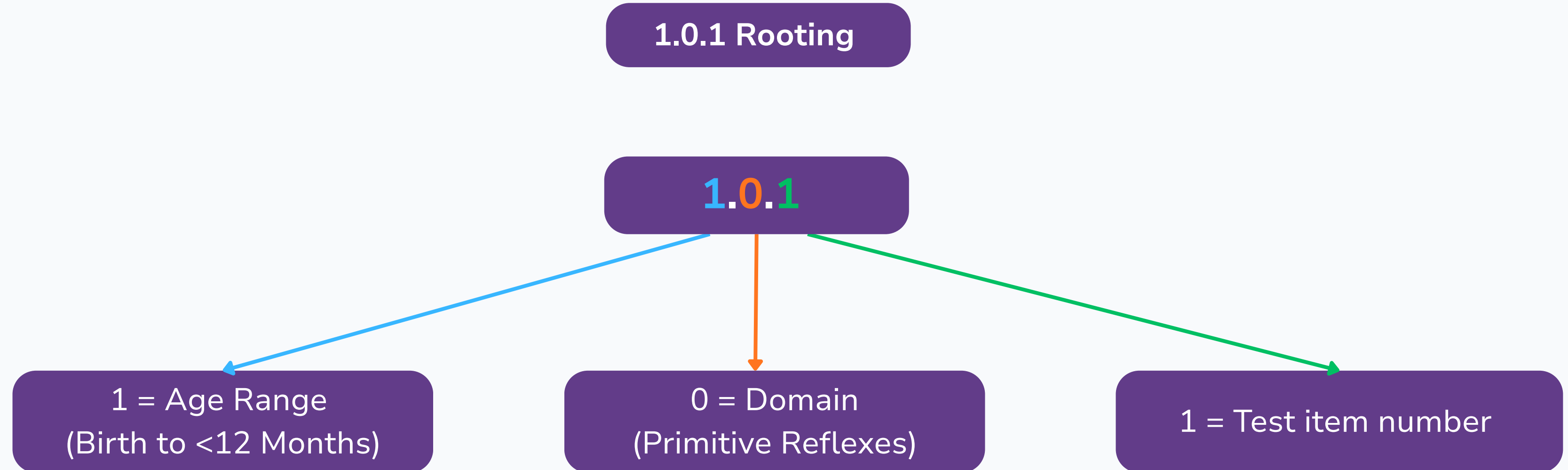
Functional Domain	Degree of risk		
	Low (Typical) = 0	Moderate = 1	High = 2
0. Primitive reflexes			
	Reflex Response		
1.0.1 Rooting	Present 0	Weak 1	None 2
1.0.2 Sucking	Present 0	Weak 1	None 2
1.0.3 Palmar grasp	Present 0	Weak 1	None 2
1.0.4 Moro	Present 0	Weak 1	None 2
1.0.5 Placing	Present 0	Weak 1	None 2
1.0.6 Stepping	Present 0	Weak 1	None 2
Primitive Reflexes Total Score (sum of scores for all items within this domain)			

RNDA-AUS: AGE-SPECIFIC SCORE FORM			
Form	Age Range		
32	13 to 16 Years		
Child Name:		Chronological Age:	
Test Date:		Corrected Age (if applicable):	
Birth Date:		Sex:	
Examiner:			

1. Gross Motor	Able = 1	Not Able = 2	
2.1.1 Walks steadily without assistance			
2.1.2 Climbs stairs with alternate feet, not holding on			
Gross Motor Total Score (sum of scores for all items within this domain)			
Degree of Gross Motor Impairment (circle)			
No Impairment/Typical	Mild	Moderate	Severe
Child walks steadily and climbs stairs without support, with alternate feet	Can walk but needs help in climbing steps or can walk and climb steps independently but unsteadily	Can walk with help	Unable to walk even with substantial help
Comments			

Item Numbering System

Test items are now numbered using a system that references the broader Age Group, the Domain and the Test Item Number. For example...



Updates by Domain

Primitive Reflexes & Gross Motor

Definitions have been added at the beginning of this chapter to provide administrators with guidance on positioning children in the younger age groups.

Definitions

Plane: In reference to items requiring holding a body part on the same plane as another, this refers to being level to.

Prone Position: The prone position refers to lying horizontally with the face and torso facing down. The infant lies with knees drawn up under the abdomen with pelvis high. Head is turned to one side.

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Fine Motor

Clarification of instructions for handwriting item in the 5+ Years Manual

1.2.6 Draws a shape with a tripod grasp [5 to 9 Years]

2.2.3 Writes with a tripod grasp with preferred hand [10 to 16 Years]

- Instructions specify that it is essential administrators demonstrate the tripod grasp and only score performance after this.
- For younger children (e.g., 5 years), it is developmentally typical for this skill to still be emerging so they may not yet demonstrate a consistent or fully mature tripod grasp. When scoring, ensure their performance is evaluated after you have demonstrated the expected tripod grasp.

Fine Motor

Clarification of instructions for button item in the 5+ Years Manual

1.2.7 Unbuttons and buttons shirt [5 to 9 Years)

2.2.4 Unbuttons and buttons shirt [10 to 16 Years]

- Instructions specify the child only needs to unbutton and button **one button** to be scored Able.

Vision

Clarification of instructions for vision item

Fixates on 100s & 1000s from 30cm distance [all ages from 9 months to 16 Years]

- Added guidance to select 100 & 1000 and Smarties that contrast with the green cloth.
 - Use: Yellow, Orange, Red
 - Avoid: Green, Blue, Purple
- Explanation in the RNDA Test Kit Materials section of the manual that explains the green cloth should cover as much of the table surface as possible to provide best contrast.

Hearing

Clarification of domain severity classifications for 5 + Years Manual

- Revised domain severity descriptions to align with the original RNDA-2 and improve clarity.

Typical	Mild	Moderate	Severe
No difficulties with hearing normal speech.	Difficulty with normal speech. Can hear loud voice. (Lowest dB heard 25-40 dB)	Difficulty with loud speech. Can hear shouted voice. (Lowest dB heard 40-60 dB)	Difficulty with shouted speech. Can hear amplified speech. (Lowest dB heard 60-90 dB)

Expressive Language

New item in the 5+ Years Manual



1.5.2 Takes part in conversation [5 to 9 Years]

2.5.2 Takes part in conversation [10 to 16 Years]

Instructions	Throughout the assessment, ask the child a few simple open-ended questions and observe if they answer you accordingly. For example, general rapport building questions related to their daily life, such as: - What do you usually do after school? - What is your favourite game? - Can you tell me something about one of your friends? - Do you have any pets? What kind?
Response	The child should take part in the conversation with appropriate answers .
Scoring	Able Not Able

Expressive Language

Updated Domain Name in 0 to <5 Years Manual

Speech



Expressive Language

- Updated from Speech to Expressive Language to align with 5+ Years Manual.

Expressive Language

Clarification of instructions for Expressive Language items

1.5.5 Loud Vocalisations [5 Months]

- The item was previously titled “Loud vocalisations and makes raspberries.”
- Wording has been updated to remove “makes raspberries”, as this is not required for the item to be scored as typical.

1.5.1 Able to say a meaningful sentence of 4-6 words [5 to 9 Years]

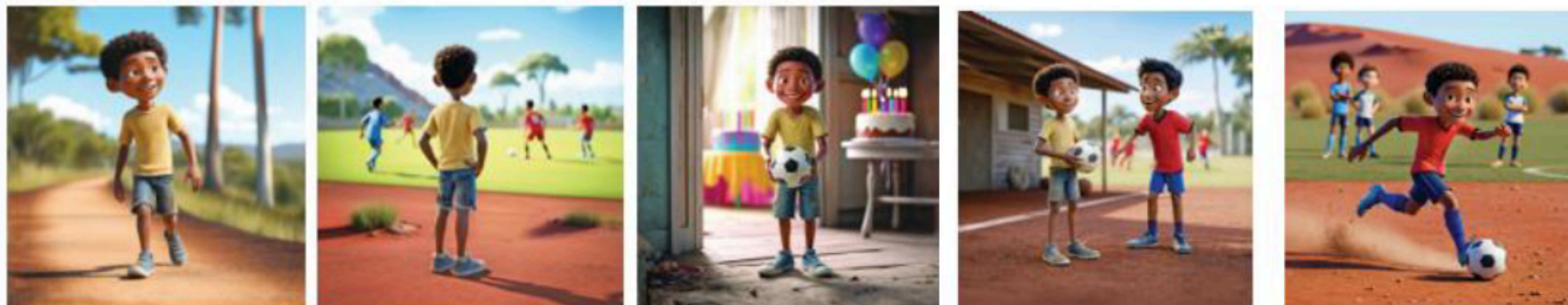
2.5.1 Able to say a meaningful sentence of > 6 words [10 to 16 Years]

- Added ‘meaningful sentence’ to ensure child is only scored as Able if words are put together meaningfully.

Cognition

New story cards in 5 + Years Manual

2.6.3 Arranges pictures that make a story [10 to 16 Years]



- This is the intended sequence of the story cards. However, an alternative order is acceptable if the child tells a logical and coherent story.

Cognition

Clarification of instructions for drawing a person in 5+ Years Manual

1.6.4 Draws a person as best they can (head, body, arms, legs) [5 to 9 Years]

2.6.2 Draws a person as best they can (head, neck, trunk, arms, legs, fingers, toes, mouth, nose, eyes, ears, hair) [10 to 16 Years]

- Tell child to do their best drawing
- For 10 to 16 year olds, tell them they should draw the person without shoes and not to draw a stick figure.
- Prompt the child 3 times to “check what they have missed” if certain body parts missing
 - For 5 to 9 = head, body, arms, or legs
 - For 10 to 16 = hair, ears, nose, eyes, mouth, fingers, or toes

Cognition

Clarification of instructions for describing a game in 5+ Years Manual

2.6.1 Describes a game (5 types of descriptions) [10 to 16 Years]

- More examples of games and acceptable descriptions
- Added clarification that a video game may only be selected if no other suitable game can be identified (after supporting the child to think of alternative games).

Self-Care

Updated Scoring in 5+ Years Manual

- For all Self-Care items, the scoring has been updated to:
 - **Able**
 - **Sometimes with help / Not able**

Seizure

Updated Scoring in both Manuals to align with the original RNDA-2

- Review grading options for Seizure item from 3 - 60 Months
- Revised domain severity descriptions in 5 + Years Manual

Typical	Mild	Moderate	Severe
The child has not experienced any episode of seizure in the past year.	One or more than one unprovoked seizure in the past year but not in the past month.	One or more than one unprovoked seizure in the past month.	More than one unprovoked seizure in the past week.